ANTHONY PENWRIGHT

C-Suite Advisor · Smart Cities · Digital Infrastructure · Innovation Ecosystems

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Executive Summary

I'm drawn to the hard problems at the edge of technology and human institutions — the places where ambitious ideas meet the messy reality of how governments, communities and industries actually operate. For two decades, that's been my work: sitting between the boardroom and the delivery room, translating intent into systems that hold.

What I do is make complexity legible. I listen first, map the terrain — politics, technology, money, people — and shape interventions that can actually move through all of them. When things work, it's rarely because of one brilliant idea; it's because every layer below the decision was designed to carry it.

Lately I've been codifying what I've learned into four practitioner frameworks so the next generation of leaders don't have to repeat the same expensive mistakes. I build ventures inside my own studio to keep the craft sharp. If you're standing at the start of something ambitious and need a partner who can see the whole board and stay in it with you — that's what I'm here for.

Proven architect of high-performance cross-functional teams (450+ resources), C-suite adviser on IoT/AI/big-data strategy, and experienced navigator of complex regulatory and government approval environments. Deep expertise across cloud infrastructure (Azure, AWS), OT/IT convergence, ERP transformation (SAP, Oracle Fusion, Dynamics 365), cybersecurity and data governance — with extensive GCC/MENA operating experience and a current Riyadh base.

Trusted C-suite advisor who translates complex technical roadmaps into measurable business outcomes. Dual MBA-qualified (Entrepreneurial Action; Artificial Intelligence in progress). PRINCE2 Practitioner · MSP · ITIL v3 · CompTIA Security+ · BTA Blockchain Professional. UK SC / DV eligible (FCO & MoD history).

Portfolio at a Glance

$1.3BN+	40+	13	7	4
Programme value delivered	Major programmes led	Sectors delivered	Active ventures (Verax)	Proprietary frameworks

How I Add Value

Strategic Clarity. Cut through complexity with framework-led thinking — translate vision into a sequenced, procurement-ready roadmap that boards, ministers and operators can all act on.

Programme Delivery at Scale. Proven track record running £100M–£1BN+ portfolios across 242 sites and 150+ countries — directing 450+ cross-functional resources against hard SLA, uptime and ROI commitments.

Framework-Led Advisory. Author of four proprietary methodologies (Smart Services, Ecosystem, Operations, VRO) grounded in ISO 37120/37122, BSI PAS 181, ITU-T L.1600 and IEC 62443.

Innovation Ecosystem Building. Build the connective tissue — demand/supply scoring, funnels, PoC-to-scale governance — that turns innovation from theatre into compounding, measurable ROI.

Sector Coverage

- Smart Cities — Greenfield
- Smart Cities — Brownfield
- Airports & Aviation
- Ports & Maritime
- Industrial / OT & Mining
- Campus & Education
- Malls & Retail
- Lifestyle Developments
- Urban Operations
- Central Government
- Defence
- Diplomatic / FCO

Global Standards & Frameworks Applied

ISO 37120:2018 (City Services & Quality of Life Indicators) · ISO 37122:2019 (Smart City Indicators) · BSI PAS 181 (Smart City Framework for Decision-Makers) · ITU-T L.1600 / FG-SSC (Smart Sustainable Cities KPI Framework) · IEC 62443 (Industrial Cybersecurity, OT & ICS) · ITIL v3 · ISO 27001 · GDPR · TOGAF ADM · PRINCE2 / MSP

Four Proprietary Frameworks — Verax Venture Studio IP

Developed inside Verax Venture Studio and distilled from live engagements at DMCC Uptown Dubai, NEOM Sindalah, Red Sea Global, Strive Services Group and Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality (IBB).

1. Smart Services Advisory — *the HOW of smart-city delivery*

3-layer service definition (Sense → Analyse → Act) · 6-stage pathway (Discovery → Identification → Prioritisation → Design → Procure → Execute) · 7-domain taxonomy (People & Welcome, Smart Energy, Smart Water, Smart Environment, Robotics, Vision AI & Safety, Smart Facilities) · 21-measure scoring with 4× Feasibility multiplier → Impact-vs-Feasibility quadrant · 8 delivered outputs per engagement (Service Catalogue, Architecture Blueprint, Living Lab Plan, Test Framework, TOM, Business Model, RFP Pack, Governance + KPIs).

Live deployment. *Deployed: 150+ smart services mapped and 40+ smart-city initiatives delivered end-to-end — DMCC Uptown Dubai, NEOM Sindalah, Red Sea Global.*

2. Innovation Ecosystem Advisory — *the WHAT — the pipeline*

8-Pillar Ecosystem Model (Vision & Strategic Alignment, R&A, Investment & Funding, Demand Side, Supply Side, Government Programmes, Talent & Skills, Enablers) · 7-stage Innovation Funnel with 3–4% conversion · dual scoring (Demand 5×26 measures, Supply 5 categories) with Fit ≥80% fast-track · benchmarks: ~85% implementation success, 100%+ ROI over 3 years, ~14-month payback.

Live deployment. *Deployed: 8 Living Labs delivered, 85+ pilots landed — Strive Services Group (KSA) smart-FM demand pipeline, vendor registry and governance committee established.*

3. Smart City Operations Advisory — *the RUN — steady-state excellence*

TOM design, service transition, NOC/SOC architecture and 24/7 operations model (greenfield or brownfield) · 60+ SOP library (incident, change, escalation, service restoration) mapped to ITIL v3 · hyper-automation and AI-driven anomaly detection reducing manual incident handling by 40% · Northbound application layer (citizen apps, operator dashboards, CCC interfaces, OSS/BSS).

Live deployment. *Delivered: 99.9% uptime at NEOM · 99.8% SLA at FCO across 242 sites / 150+ countries · Cisco IBB Istanbul architecture blueprint.*

4. Value Realisation Office (VRO) — *the KEEP DELIVERING engine*

VRO ≠ PMO — PMO governs delivery (time, scope, cost); VRO governs value (outcomes, ROI, evolution). 3 parallel operating modes (Value Realisation, Operational Excellence, Adaptive/Evolving) · 3 permanent workstreams (Service Portfolio & Business Model, Technology Blueprint, Operating Model) · 3 strategic imperatives · 4 live input feeds · 5 standing outputs (Innovation Stimulus, 12-month rolling Roadmap, Risk Register, 3-year Investments Forecast, PoC pipeline).

Live deployment. *Deployed: NEOM (Innovation governance board), Quantela (outcome-based commercial model), Cisco global smart city practice.*

Ecosystem (WHAT) → Smart Services (HOW) → Operations (RUN) → VRO (KEEP DELIVERING)

A closed loop — VRO feeds new ideation back into the Ecosystem funnel, preventing programme drift and sustaining ROI beyond Phase 2.

Professional Experience

Director of Innovation · NEOM Nov 2024 – Present | £93M | Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

- Spearhead technology, innovation and partnerships strategy for the world's largest giga-project — engaging NEOM sectors and regions to identify critical and emerging technology needs across smart infrastructure, AI, IoT and data.
- Govern evaluation of AI, IoT, digital twin, edge and autonomous systems for deployment across THE LINE, SINDALAH and TROJENA — setting KPIs, SLAs and operational frameworks for pilot programmes.
- Cultivate high-impact global partnerships with technology leaders, venture capital firms and sovereign investors. Awarded 'Best Performing Employee' in a sector of 600+ staff.

Director of Technology & Digital · NEOM Apr 2023 – Nov 2024 | £230M | Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

- Headhunted to lead 90+ resources delivering NEOM's digital master plan — Smart City platforms, IoT infrastructure and OT systems across Urban Planning and Islands divisions.
- Defined and governed the Cloud-Edge Collaborative infrastructure strategy — multi-cloud (Azure IoT, AWS), on-premises environments and distributed edge nodes processing real-time IoT data.
- Delivered smart building and OT systems (BMS, ACS, CCTV, AV/ELV, structured cabling) end-to-end, and built the 24/7 NOC capability that achieved 99.9% uptime across critical infrastructure.
- Applied Verax Smart Services Advisory at NEOM Sindalah — scored and prioritised services across 7 domains, producing procurement-ready Service Catalogue and Architecture Blueprint.

Founder & Principal — Smart City Advisory · Verax Venture Studio 2022 – Present | Concurrent | UAE / KSA / LATAM

- Founded Verax to codify 20 years of smart city delivery into four vendor-agnostic methodologies: Smart Services Advisory, Innovation Ecosystem Advisory, Operations Advisory and VRO.
- DMCC Uptown Dubai: applied 6-stage pathway to score 40+ candidate services using 21-measure framework — delivered full procurement-ready portfolio (Blueprint, RFP Pack, Governance & KPIs).
- Strive Services Group (KSA): deployed Innovation Ecosystem Advisory to structure smart-FM demand pipeline — dual demand/supply scoring, vendor registry and governance committee established.
- Built a 31-agent hierarchical AI orchestration platform automating email triage, CRM enrichment, procurement and cost monitoring — eliminating 80%+ of manual operational overhead at $30/month total platform cost.

Director — Smart Cities & IoT · Wipro Technologies Apr 2022 – Apr 2023 | £80M | Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

- Established Wipro's Arabian entity reporting directly to CEO — strategy, growth and IoT programme delivery for NEOM and Red Sea Global giga-projects; led 70+ resources.
- Delivered KSA's first Smart Luggage Services and advanced EV fleet management — full product lifecycle from design through to 24/7 NOC-based operational support.
- Built operational service delivery capability (NOC, helpdesk, field services) supporting 24/7 OT infrastructure operations across client sites.

Director — Growth & Delivery · Quantela (Smart Cities Platform) Sept 2021 – Apr 2022 | £98M | Global

- Recruited by Board to drive strategic growth — increased company revenue from $18M to $90M (400%) with $300M+ pipeline through strategic business model transformation.
- Forged key commercial and investor relationships including the $2BN Digital Alpha fund; delivered first major deal closure through outcome-based, revenue-sharing commercial framework.

Smart City Global Advisory Lead & Programme Director · Cisco Systems Nov 2015 – Apr 2021 | £250M | Global

- Established and scaled Cisco's global Smart Cities and IoT practice from zero — delivering programmes across 10+ city deployments in Europe, Middle East and Asia-Pacific, individual programmes up to £45M.
- Designed ITIL-aligned operational service models for Smart City platforms — SOPs, incident management, NOC frameworks and performance optimisation standards.
- Provided CXO-level advisory across public sector, utilities and telecoms — translating OT/IT convergence strategy into scalable platform and connectivity solutions.

- Directed product strategy, go-to-market and EMEA systems-integrator partnerships for Cisco's Connected Cities and IoT portfolio.

Programme Director — Public Service Network · Cabinet Office Mar 2013 – Nov 2015 | £18M p.a. | United Kingdom

- Worked directly with Cabinet Ministers to deliver technology strategy for Public Service Authorities — managed 48 suppliers and governed Local Authority CTO/CEO/COO leadership.
- Established operational service management framework — SLAs, incident, change control and performance reporting for public sector OT/IT infrastructure.

Programme Director · Environment Agency Dec 2011 – Mar 2013 | £38M | United Kingdom

- Brought into a failing central government department to redefine enterprise ways of working — established Enterprise Architecture office and PMO, leading 24 project managers to successful outcomes.

Director, Strategic Operations · Foreign & Commonwealth Office Aug 2008 – Dec 2011 | £768M | Global

- Reported to the Foreign Secretary and CIO — governed global service delivery operations across 242 sites in 150+ countries, single point of contact for all Ambassadors and Deputy Heads of Mission.
- Led 24/7 NOC operations, service desk, infrastructure operations and business continuity across secure diplomatic OT/IT networks — 450+ indirect reports, 99.8% SLA, ISO 27001 compliance.

Programme Director — YJB · Ministry of Justice Feb 2008 – Aug 2008 | £7M | United Kingdom

- Delivered Youth Justice Board technology programme — governance, commercial control and stakeholder management across central government and partner agencies.

Overseas Programme Director — DII(F) · Ministry of Defence Nov 2005 – Aug 2008 | £1BN+ | Global

- Led consortium delivery of 5 large enterprise organisations on one of the largest global business change programmes of its time — Defence Information Infrastructure (Future): 150,000 workstations, 300,000 users, 2,000 sites.
- Directed programme management and enterprise architecture across classified defence infrastructure, working to UK Government TS/SC security standards.

Transformation Lead · Corus Steel Aug 2004 – Nov 2005 | £19M | United Kingdom

- Led enterprise transformation programme across industrial manufacturing operations — process re-engineering, systems consolidation and operational readiness for integrated steel sites.

Implementation Lead · Department for Work and Pensions (DWP) Mar 2004 – Aug 2005 | £4M | United Kingdom

- Delivered enterprise implementation across DWP — requirements, design, build and transition into live public-sector operations.

Deployment Lead · HM Prison Service Jan 2003 – Mar 2004 | £6M | United Kingdom

- Managed estate-wide deployment programme across HM Prison Service secure sites — rollout planning, risk management and operational handover under strict security and custodial constraints.

Core Competencies

Smart City & Digital Infrastructure

- IoT Architecture & Platform Design (Azure IoT, 5G/NB-IoT)
- AI/ML, Vision AI & Big Data Analytics
- Smart Energy, Water, Mobility & Facilities
- OT/IT Convergence · SCADA / OPC · V2X
- Edge & Hybrid Cloud · Multi-Cloud (Azure, AWS)
- Urban Digital Twin · BMS / ACS / CCTV / AV-ELV
- Enterprise Connectivity · 5G / 4G / LTE / NB-IoT
- ERP Transformation (SAP, Oracle Fusion, Dynamics 365, AX12)
- Blockchain, Web3 & Autonomous Systems
- Cybersecurity & Compliance (ISO 27001, IEC 62443, GDPR)

Executive Leadership & Strategy

- C-Suite Advisory & Board-Level Communication
- P&L, CAPEX/OPEX & Financial Forecasting
- Regulatory & Government Affairs · M&A · PPP
- Cross-Functional Team Leadership (450+ resources)
- Vendor Negotiation & 48+ Supplier Governance
- Innovation Ecosystem Development
- Agile · PRINCE2 · MSP · ITIL v3 · TOGAF ADM
- Procurement, RFP Design & Commercial Modelling
- Performance Management & KPI Governance
- Living Lab / Model Office / TOM Design

Certifications

PRINCE2 Practitioner · MSP (Managing Successful Programmes) · ITIL v3 Service Management · CompTIA A+ & Security+ · BTA Blockchain Professional · BTA Solution Architect · Microsoft Azure / M365

Education

MBA — Entrepreneurial Action. Anglia Ruskin University, Cambridge · 2025.

MBA — Artificial Intelligence (in progress). University of Cumbria · Expected 2026.

Postgraduate-Level Strategic Management and Leadership.

Security & Languages

UK Security Clearance: SC / DV eligible (FCO & MoD history). · English (native). · Saudi Arabia Premium Resident — available for global opportunities.

Interests

Technology · Motorbike Racing · Self-Development · Volunteering · CrossFit · Travel & Culture.

References

Available on request.